

CHAPTER 1 Orientations Toward Objects

In perception properly so-called, as an explicit awareness (*Gewahren*), I am turned towards the object, to the paper, for instance, I apprehend it as being this here and now. The apprehension is a singling out, every perceived object having a background in experience. Around and about the paper lie books, pencils, ink-well, and so forth, and these in a certain sense are also “perceived,” perceptually there, in the “field of intuition.”

Edmund Husserl, *Ideas*

Phenomenology is often characterized as a “turn toward” objects, which appear in their perceptual “thereness” as objects given to consciousness. Rather than consciousness being seen as directed toward itself, it is understood as having objects in its view—as being shaped by that which appears before it in “this here and now.” But in turning toward objects, what actually appears within phenomenological writing? If phenomenology apprehends what is given to consciousness, then what is given within the writing about that apprehension? Or, in simpler terms, what objects appear within phenomenology as objects that the reader, in turn, can apprehend?

In Husserl’s *Ideas* objects do appear for sure, though we cannot assume that they record an experience, in the sense that we cannot assume that Husserl saw or even “could see” the object at the moment of writing. As with much philosophy, the object appears in the language of “say” or “for instance”: that is, “say, I see this”; or “for instance, I see that.” Such words preface the example as illustration and not anecdote—the point is not whether or not this *really* happened. The object appears not as a thing to which we should, as readers, direct

our attention; it is not so much *a thing* as a way of saying something. And yet objects still become apprehended in the reading *as if* they were what Husserl was himself directed toward; the *as if* makes the objects matter not “in themselves,” or even “for themselves,” but as that which the writing is “around.” The objects do not take the shape of an event, in the sense of recording something that happens or is happening, even though they allow phenomenology to take the shape that it does.

And yet, as Husserl notes, the object that is “singled out,” or becomes available as a singular given, is “the paper,” earlier described as “this white paper” (116). The object is an object that one imagines “would have been” in front of Husserl in the moment of writing, or even that “must have been” before him if the writing were to be written. We know enough about the “timing” of Husserl’s writing to know, for instance, that what was in front of him was paper rather than a screen. Of course, the paper that Husserl might apprehend is not available to the reader. The paper can only be “missed” given that it is first apprehended as an object in the writing, which itself is dependent on the availability of paper. This paper weaves together the book I read *as* Husserl’s book, and it was not available or “thrown” into Husserl’s world as that which could appear to him. This paper, which was not given to him, must nevertheless be given in order for Husserl’s writing to be given to me. I read writing printed on paper, and *on* the paper I read *about* the paper that is apprehended by Husserl. The paper is also “in” the writing, and hence the writing is “around” the paper. Around the paper are other objects, which are not singled out and thus form the “background” against and through which the paper appears. These again are tools of writing: inkwell, books, and pencils. The field of background intuition, against which the object becomes posited as given (the paper) provides for Husserl the very “stuff” for writing, the very materials out of which his phenomenology is borne.

How does the “matter” of the paper matter? How does the orientation of the paper, which is “on” the writing table, also function as an orientation device, which both shows the “direction” of phenomenology and also takes it in a certain direction? In this chapter I explore the concept of orientation by engaging with the work on objects by Husserl, Heidegger, and Merleau-Ponty, as well as Marx. By reflecting specifically on “the table” as an object that matters within phenomenology, I also offer an account of gender as oriented. My aim is not to develop a phenomenology of sexual difference, as this

has already convincingly been offered by feminist philosophers (see Beauvoir 1989; Young 1990, 2005; Heinämaa 2003; Fisher and Embree 2000). Instead, by showing how phenomenology faces a certain direction, which depends on the relegation of other “things” to the background, I consider how phenomenology may be gendered as a form of occupation.

Objects of Perception

The radical claim that phenomenology inherits from Franz Brentano’s psychology is that consciousness is intentional: it is directed toward something. This claim immediately links the question of the object with that of orientation. First, consciousness itself is directed or orientated toward objects, which is what gives consciousness its “worldly” dimension. If consciousness is about how we perceive the world “around” us, then consciousness is also embodied, sensitive, and situated. This thesis does not simply function as a general thesis, but can also help show us how bodies are directed in some ways and not others, as a way of inhabiting or dwelling in the world.

We are turned toward things. Such things make an impression upon us. We perceive them as things insofar as they are near to us, insofar as we share a residence with them. Perception hence involves orientation; what is perceived depends on where we are located, which gives us a certain take on things. Merleau-Ponty makes this point directly when he suggests that “the word perception indicates a direction rather than a primitive function” (1962: 12). Perception is a way of facing something. I can perceive an object only insofar as my orientation allows me to see it (it must be near enough to me, which in turn means that I must be near enough to it), and in seeing it, in this way or that, it becomes an “it,” which means I have already taken an orientation toward it. The object is an effect of towardness; it is the thing toward which I am directed and which in being posited as a thing, as being something or another for me, takes me in some directions rather than others.

For example, say I perceive something before me. In perceiving the object as an object, I perceive the object *in a certain way*, as being some kind of thing. Perceiving an object involves a way of apprehending that object. So it is not just that consciousness is directed toward objects, but also that I take different directions toward objects: I might like them, admire them, hate them, and so on. In perceiving them in this way or that, I also take a position upon them,

which in turns gives me a position. I might perceive an object as beautiful, for instance. Such a perception affects what I do: if I have this impression, then I might pick up the object, or get closer to it, and even press it nearer to me. Orientations involve directions toward objects that affect what we do, and how we inhabit space. We move toward and away from objects depending on how we are moved by them. For Husserl, the interpretation of the object as having this or that property is a secondary act involving what he calls a “twofold directedness” (1969: 122).¹ First, I am directed toward an object (I face it), and then I take a direction toward it (for instance, I might or might not admire it). While directionality might be twofold, this “twofoldness” does not necessarily involve a sequence in time: in seeing the object I already apprehend it in a certain way, as a concrete “it” that has qualities that might attract or repel me, or even leave me indifferent, which might affect how “it” enters my view and whether it stays in view or passes from view.² Turning toward an object turns “me” in this way or that, even if that “turn” does not involve a conscious act of interpretation or judgment.

We might ask, then, which way does Husserl turn? If Husserl turns toward certain objects in his writing, then what does this tell us *in turn* about his phenomenology? Let us start where he starts in his first volume of *Ideas*, which is with the world as it is given “from the natural standpoint.” Such a world is the world that we are “in,” as the world that takes place around us: “I am aware of a world, spread out in space endlessly” (1969: 101). This world is not simply spread out; rather, it has already taken certain shapes, which are the very form of what is “more and less” familiar: As Husserl states: “For me real objects are there, definite, more or less familiar, agreeing with what is actually perceived without being themselves perceived or even intuitively present. I can let my attention wander from the writing-table I have just seen and observed, through the unseen portions of the room behind my back to the veranda, into the garden, to the children in the summer-house, and so forth, to all the objects concerning which I precisely ‘know’ that they are there and yonder in my immediate co-perceived surroundings” (101).

The familiar world begins with the writing table, which is in “the room”: we can name this room as Husserl’s study or as the room in which he writes. *It is from here that the world unfolds.* He begins with the writing table and then turns to other parts of the room, those that are, as it were, behind him. To make this turn, we might suppose that he would have to turn around if he is to

face what is behind him. But, of course, Husserl does not need to turn around as he “knows” what is behind him. And yet his mind wanders, as if thoughts are actions that demand that he turn around to face or “attend” to what is behind him. The verb “wander” helps us track the significance of “attention” as a mode of “turning toward.” To “wander” can mean to ramble without certain course, to go aimlessly, to take one direction without intention or control, to stray from a path, or even to deviate in conduct or belief. So Husserl in attending to what is behind him is deviating from his proper course. The behind is here the “point” of deviation, such that when Husserl considers what is behind his back, he is turning his attention away from what he faces.

We are reminded that what we can see in the first place depends on which way we are facing. What gets our attention depends too on which direction we are facing. The things that are behind Husserl are also behind the table that he faces: it is “self-evident” that he has his back to what is behind him. We might even say that it is the behind that converts “the back” into the background. A queer phenomenology, I wonder, might be one that faces the back, which looks “behind” phenomenology, which hesitates at the sight of the philosopher’s back. Having begun here, with what is in front of his front and behind his back, Husserl then turns to other spaces, which he describes as rooms, and which he “knows” are there insofar as they are already given to him as places by memory. These other rooms are co-perceived: that is, they are not singled out and they do not have his attention, even when he evokes them for the reader. They are made available to us only as background features of this domestic landscape.

Husserl’s writing makes an impression on me when he offers this glimpse of the domesticity of his world. How I long for him to dwell there by lingering on the folds of the materials that surround him. How I long to hear about the objects that gather around him, as “things” he does “things” with. This is not a desire for biography, or even for an impossible intimacy with a writer who is no longer with us. This is, rather, a desire to read about the particularity of the objects that gather around the writer. It is also a desire to imagine philosophy as beginning here, with the pen and the paper, and with the body of the philosopher, who writes insofar as he is “at home” and insofar as home provides a space in which he does his work.

Yes, we are invited, at least temporarily, to imagine the world that is his home; to give it a face and a form. I see his desk in the corner. I see him at his

desk—leaning, writing, pressing pen to paper, creating the lines that make these impressions available to me. I see a leather chair to one side. I have such an image, such an impression already in mind. The study, the room dedicated to writing or other forms of contemplation, conjures up such a vivid image of a masculine domain at the front of the house. I imagine the furniture (dark, polished), the materials (leather, wood), and the feel of the room (serious, intense), even though I know I do not and will not know how he arranged his room. His words help to create these impressions. But my impression of this study does not begin with the words written on this paper. My impressions are affected by other books I have read in my own literary genealogy, especially nineteenth-century women's writing, which is saturated with images of domestic space. The study, the parlor, the kitchen: these rooms provide the settings for drama; they are where things happen.

The family home provides, as it were, the background against which an object (the writing table) appears in the present, in front of Husserl. The family home is thus only ever *co-perceived*, and allows the philosopher to do his work. This familiar place, the family home, is also a practical world: "Things in their immediacy stand there as objects to be used, the 'table with its books,' the 'glass to drink from,' the 'vase,' the 'piano,' and so forth" (1969: 103). If Husserl is facing the writing table, then this "direction" also shows us the nature of the work that he does for a living. It is the table, with its books, which first gets his attention. As Diana Fuss reminds us, "the theatre of composition is not an empty space but a place animated by the artefacts, momentos, machines, books, and furniture that frame any intellectual labour" (2004: 1).

The objects that first appear as the "more and less familiar" function as signs of orientation: being orientated toward the writing table might ensure that you inhabit certain rooms and not others, and that you do some things rather than others. In the following sections I will take up the significance of this example in terms of "doing things" and "inhabiting spaces." Being orientated toward the writing table not only relegates other rooms in the house to the background, but also might depend *on the work done to keep the desk clear*. The desk that is clear is one that is ready for writing. One might even consider the domestic work that must have taken place for Husserl to turn to the writing table, and to be writing on the table, and to keep that table as the object of his attention. We can draw here on the long history of feminist scholarship about the politics of housework: about the ways in which women, as wives and

servants, do the work required to keep such spaces available for men and the work they do (Gilman 2002).³ To sustain an orientation toward the writing table might depend on such work, while it erases the signs of that work, as signs of dependence. In Ruth Madigan and Moira Munro's critique of the town house, they note how its interior design "reflected the internal hierarchy of the bourgeois family with the public 'masculine' domain at the front of the house, and the private 'feminine' domain confined to the rear" (1990: 7). What is behind Husserl's back, what he does not face, might be the back of the house—the feminine space dedicated to the work of care, cleaning, and reproduction. Such work is often experienced as "the lack of spare time" (Davies 2001: 141); for example, the lack of time for oneself or for contemplation. To what extent does philosophy depend on the concealment of domestic labor and of the labor time that it takes to reproduce the very "materials" of home?

It is interesting to note, for instance, that in Husserl's writing, the familiar slides into the familial; the home is a family home as a residence that is inhabited by children. They are in the summer house, he tells us. The children evoke the familial only through being "yonder"—through being at a distance from the philosopher who in writing "about" them is doing his work. They are outside the house yet also part of its interior, near the "veranda," which marks "the edge," a line between what is inside and what is outside. In a way, the children who are "yonder" point to what is made available through memory or even habitual knowledge: they are sensed as being there, behind him, even if they are not seen by him at this moment in time. The children might be in the background because others (wives, mothers, nannies) care for them. They do not distract him from his work.

We can think, in other words, of the background not simply in terms of what is around what we face, as the "dimly perceived," but as produced by acts of relegation: some things are relegated to the background in order *to sustain* a certain direction; in other words, in order to keep attention on what is faced. Perception involves such acts of relegation that are forgotten in the very preoccupation with what it is that is faced. We can pose a simple question: Who faces the writing table? Does the writing table have a face, which points it toward some bodies rather than others? If such acts of facing depend on relegating the children or other dependants to the background, then the answer to this question would not simply involve a biographical approach, but would consider how other forms of social orientation affect how bodies

arrive at the table. One could read Husserl alongside other writers who have written about writing. Let's consider Adrienne Rich's account of writing a letter: "From the fifties and early sixties, I remember a cycle. It began when I had picked up a book or began trying to write a letter . . . The child (or children) might be absorbed in busyness, in his own dream world; but as soon as he felt me gliding into a world which did not include him, he would come to pull at my hand, ask for help, punch at the typewriter keys. And I would feel his wants at such a moment as fraudulent, as an attempt moreover to defraud me of living even for fifteen minutes as myself" (Rich 1991: 23).⁴

We can see from the point of view of this mother, who is also a writer, a poet, and a philosopher, that giving attention to the objects of writing, facing those objects, becomes impossible: the children, even if they are behind you, literally pull you away. This loss of time for writing feels like a loss of your own time, as you are returned to the work of giving your attention to the children. Attention involves a political economy, or an uneven distribution of attention time between those who arrive at the writing table, which affects what they can do once they arrive (and of course, many do not even make it). For some, having time for writing, which means time to face the objects upon which writing happens, becomes an orientation that is not available given the ongoing labor of other attachments, which literally pull you away. So whether we can sustain our orientation toward the writing table depends on other orientations, which affect what we can face at any given moment in time.

By reading the objects that appear in Husserl's writing, we get a sense of how being directed toward some objects and not others involves a more general orientation toward the world. The objects that we direct our attention toward reveal the direction we have taken in life. Other objects, and indeed spaces, are relegated to the background; they are only ever co-perceived. This relegation of unseen portions and the rooms to the background, as the fringe of the familiar, which is not the object of attention, is followed by a second act of relegation. For although Husserl directs our attention to these other rooms, *even if only as the background to his writing table*, he also suggests that phenomenology must "bracket" or put aside what is given, what is made available by ordinary perception. If phenomenology is to see the table, he suggests, it must see "without" the natural attitude, which keeps us within the familiar—indeed, within the space already "decided" as "being" the family home.

So this turn toward objects within phenomenology (which as we see is about some objects and not others) is not about the characteristics of such objects, which we can define in terms of type, the kind of objects they are, or their function, which names not only the “tendency” of the objects, what they do, but also what they allow us to do: the paper (what I write on), the pencil (what I write with), and so on. The social and familiar character of objects is “bracketed” by Husserl, as what is posited by the natural attitude, the attitude that in turn is inherited by psychologism and that takes for granted what is given to the subject as given (Husserl 1969: 16). The natural attitude does not “see the world,” as it takes for granted what appears; what appears quickly disappears under the blanket of the familiar. In such a world, everything is orientated around me, as being available and familiar to me (Schutz and Luckmann 1974: 4). To see the paper, for instance, as simply the material that is available to write upon (the paper is white paper, even blank paper, as that which is *ready* for me to write upon), would not be to perceive the paper *as an object*. Phenomenology, in Husserl’s formulation, can only come into being as a first philosophy, if it suspends all that gathers together as a natural attitude, not through Cartesian doubt but through a way of perceiving the world “as if” one did not assume its existence as taking some forms rather than others (1969: 107–10). If the objects of phenomenology are domesticated objects—that is, objects one imagines as “being available” within the familiar space provided by the home—then the domesticity of the setting is not allowed to reveal itself. Or, if signs of domesticity appear then, they also quickly disappear, and seemingly must do so if phenomenology is to do its work.

This domestic world, which surrounds the philosopher as he moves his attention “backward” from the space in which he writes, must be “put aside,” or even “put to one side,” in his turn toward objects as objects of perception. It is this world, which is familiar to him, that is given in the form of familiarity. What does it mean to assume that bracketing can “transcend” the familiar world of experience? Perhaps to bracket does not mean to transcend, even if we put something aside. We remain reliant on what we put in brackets; indeed, the activity of bracketing may sustain the fantasy that “what we put aside” can be transcended in the first place.⁵ The act of “putting aside” might also confirm the fantasy of a subject who is transcendent, who places himself above the contingent world of social matter, a world that differentiates objects and subjects according to how they already appear. We could question not only

the formal aspects of the bracket (which creates the fantasy that we can do without what we put to one side), but also with the content of what is bracketed, with “what” is “put aside.”⁶ What is “put aside,” we might say, is the very space of the familiar, which is also what clears the philosopher’s table and allows him to do his work.

The objects that appear within phenomenology also disappear in the “passing over” of what is given as familiar (the paper is first named, and then would become something other than *that* as if it were *that* then I would be writing on the paper, rather than seeing it). This disappearance of familiar objects might make more than the object disappear. The writer who does the work of philosophy might disappear, if we are to erase the signs of “where” it is that he works. Feminist philosophers have shown us how the masculinity of philosophy is evidenced in the disappearance of the subject under the sign of the universal (Bordo 1987; Irigaray 1974; Braidotti 1991). The masculinity might also be evident in the disappearance of the materiality of objects, in the bracketing of the materials out of which, as well as upon which, philosophy writes itself, as a way of apprehending the world.

We could call this the fantasy of a “paperless” philosophy, a philosophy that is not dependent on the materials upon which it is written. As Audre Lorde reflects, “A room of one’s own may be a necessity for writing prose, but so are reams of paper, a type writer and plenty of time” (1984: 116). The fantasy of a paperless philosophy can be understood as crucial not only to the gendered nature of the occupation of philosophy but also to the disappearance of political economy, of the “materials” of philosophy as well as its dependence on forms of labor, both domestic and otherwise. In other words, the labor of writing might disappear along with the paper. The paper here matters, both as the object upon which writing is written, but also as the condition of possibility for that work. If the suspension of the natural attitude, which sees itself as seeing beyond the familiar, or even seeing through it, involves *putting the paper aside*, then it might involve the concealment of the labor of philosophy, as well as the labor that allows philosophy to take up the time that it does. Rather than the familiar being posited as that which must be suspended in order to see, we might consider what “it” is that we “overlook” when we reside within the familiar.⁷ We would look, then, at what we do with things, how the arrival of things may be shaped by the work that we do, rather than put aside what it is that we do.

Let us return to the table. Husserl begins again by taking up the matter of the table. He has put aside the knowing glance of the natural attitude, which would see the table as a writing table, in this room, in this house, in this world. How does the object appear when it is no longer familiar? As he puts it: “We start by taking an example. Keeping this table steadily in view as I go round it, changing my position in space all the time, I have continually the consciousness of the bodily presence out there of this one and the self-same table, which in itself remains unchanged throughout” (1969: 130).

We can see here how Husserl turns to “the table” as an object by looking at it rather than over it. The writing table, if we are to follow this line, would not be seen (even if we face it, it is in the background as what is more and less familiar). For Husserl, then to see the table means to *lose sight of its function*. The bracket means “this table” becomes “the table.” By beginning with the table, on its own, as it were, the object then appears self-same. It is not that the object’s self-sameness is available at first sight. Husserl moves around the table, changing his position. For such movement to be possible, consciousness must flow: we must not be interrupted by other matters. This flow of consciousness is made possible by having the time and space to attend to the table. Putting that point to one side (we can labor points, too, after all), we might follow his gaze. Apprehending the table as an object means that I must walk around it and approach it as if I had not encountered it before; seeing it *as an object* means not describing the table as occupying a familial order, as the writing table, or any other kind of table. Such biographical or practical knowledge must be bracketed, which Husserl describes as “*to put out of action*” (1969: 110). And in the bracketing, I do not see the table as my field of action but rather see it as an object, *as if* I did not already know it or even know what I do with it. I do not see “it” in one look, but only as a series of profiles of “it,” which nevertheless allow me to posit “it” as more than what I see in any one look. As Husserl elaborates:

I close my eyes. The other senses are inactive in relation to the table. I have now no perception of it. I open my eyes and the perception returns. The perception? Let us be more accurate. Under no circumstances does it return to me individually the same. *Only the table is the same*, known as identical through the synthetic consciousness, which connects the new experience with the recollection. The perceived thing can be, without being perceived, without my being aware of it even as a potential only (in the way, actuality, as previously described) and

perhaps even without itself changing at all. But the perception itself is what it is within the steady flow of consciousness, and is itself constantly in flux; the perceptual now is ever passing over into the adjacent consciousness of the just-past, a new now simultaneously gleams forth, and so on. (130; emphasis added)

This argument suggests that the table as object is given as “the same,” as a givenness that “holds” or is shaped by the “flow” of perception. Indeed, this is precisely Husserl’s point: the object is intended through perception. As Robert Sokolowski describes, “When we perceive an object, we do not just have a flow of profiles, a series of impressions; in and through them all, we have one and the same object given to us, and the identity of the object is intended and given” (2000: 20). The “intending” of the object through which it becomes more than just one impression involves, in Husserl’s terms, synthetic consciousness—that is, the connection of the new impression with what has gone before, in the very form of an active “re-collection” or synthesis. Significantly, the object becomes an object of perception only given the work of recollection, such that the “new” exists in relation *to what is already gathered by consciousness*: each impression is linked to the other, so that the object becomes more than the profile that is available in any moment.

Given this, the story of the sameness of the object involves the specter of absence and nonpresence. For despite the self-sameness of the object, I do not see it as “the self-same.” I never see it as such; what “it is” cannot be apprehended as *I cannot view the table from all points of view at once*. The necessity of moving around the object, to capture more than its profile, shows that the object is unavailable to me, which is why it must be intended. It is a table, so I am hardly surprised to walk around, and from each view, to see a profile that matches what I expect to see. It might have four legs, or a wooden top—all of the things I would expect it to have if it is a table.

The table’s sameness can only be intended. Husserl then makes what is an extraordinary claim: *only the table remains the same*. This is, in part, extraordinary given the implication that all other things fluctuate. The table is the only thing that keeps its place in the flow of perception. This already makes the table a rather queer object (as I will explore in the conclusion of this book). We can take what is powerful about Husserl’s thesis of intentionality and suggest that the sameness of the table is spectral: the table is only the same given that we have conjured its missing sides. Or, we can even say that we have *conjured its behind*. I want to relate what is “missed” when we “miss” the table to the spectral-

ity of history, what we miss may be behind the table in another sense: what is behind the table is what must have already taken place for the table to arrive.

Objects That Arrive

As noted above, phenomenology for Husserl means apprehending the object as if it were unfamiliar, so that we can attend to the flow of perception itself. What this flow of perception shows is the partiality of absence as well as presence: what we do not see (say, the back or side of the object), is hidden from view and can only be intended. The partiality of perception is not only about what is not in view (say, the front and the back of the object), but also what is “around” it, which we can describe as the background. The figure “figures” insofar as the background both is and is not in view. We single out this object only by pushing other objects to the edges or “fringes” of vision.

Husserl suggests that inhabiting the familiar makes “things” into backgrounds for action: they are there, but they are there in such a way that I don’t see them. The background is a “*dimly apprehended depth or fringe of indeterminate reality*” (1969: 102). We can thus see that although Husserl faces his writing table, this does not mean the table is perceived as an object. Even though the table is before him, it might also be in the background. We might not even “see” the writing table when we write upon it. My argument in the previous section hence needs some qualification: even when Husserl faces the writing table, it does not necessarily follow that the table is “in front” of him. What we face can also be part of the background, suggesting that the background may include more and less proximate objects. It is not incidental that when Husserl brings “the table” to the front that the writing table disappears. Being orientated toward the writing table might even provide the condition of possibility for its disappearance.

Husserl’s approach to the background as what is “unseen” in its “thereness” or “familiarity” is extremely useful, even if he puts the familiar to one side. It allows us to consider how the familiar takes shape by being unnoticed. I want here to extend his model by thinking about the “background” of the writing table in another sense. Husserl considers how this table might be *in* the background, as well as the background that is *around* the table, when “it” comes into view. I want to consider how the table itself may *have* a background. The background would be understood as that which must take place in order for

something to appear. We can recall the different meanings of the word “background.” A background can refer to the “ground or parts situated in the rear” (such as the rooms in the back of the house), or to the portions of the picture represented at a distance, which in turn allows what is “in” the foreground to acquire the shape that it does, as a figure or object. Both of these meanings point to the “spatiality” of the background. We can also think of background as having a temporal dimension.⁸ When we tell a story about someone, for instance, we might give information about their background: this meaning of “background” would be about “what is behind,” where “what is behind” refers to what is in the past or what happened “before.” We might speak also of “family background,” which would refer not just to the past of an individual but also to other kinds of histories, which shape an individual’s arrival into the world, and through which “the family” itself becomes a social given (see chapter 2). Indeed, events can have backgrounds: a background is what explains the conditions of emergence or an arrival of something as the thing that it appears to be in the present.

So, if phenomenology is to attend to the background, it might do so by giving an account of the conditions of emergence for something, which would not necessarily be available in how that thing presents itself to consciousness. If we do not see (but intend) the back of the object, we might also not see (but intend) its background in this temporal sense. In order to see what the “natural attitude” has in its sight, we need to face the background of an object, re-defined as the conditions for the emergence not only of the object (we might ask: How did it arrive?), as well as the act of perceiving the object, which depends on the arrival of the body that perceives. The background to perception might involve such intertwining histories of arrival, which would explain how Husserl got near enough to his table for it to become not only the object on which he writes, but also the object around which his phenomenology is written. After all, phenomenology has its own background, its own conditions for emergence, which might include the very matter of the table.

So how does the object arrive into one’s field of vision? What is behind its arrival? Such a question implies that the “availability” of objects is an effect of actions, which are not necessarily perceivable on the surface of the object. The question is not a simple one; it cannot be answered by providing a biography of the object as if the object had an independent existence from the “points” at which they are viewed. Despite this, objects move in and out of view such that they do have an existence that is more than how they present or reveal them-

selves. As Arjun Appadurai suggests, “We have to follow the things themselves, for their meanings are inscribed in their forms, their uses, their trajectories” (1988: 5). If phenomenology turns us toward things, in terms of how they reveal themselves in the present, then we may also need to “follow” such things around. We may need to supplement phenomenology with an “ethnography of things.” The question of where an object “goes” would not then vacate the position of subjects, those to whom they present themselves as a figure, or background within familiar forms of the social. The story of the object’s travel would involve “co-perception,” to use Husserl’s term. So our question, as an “ethno-phenomenological” one, would be: How did I or we arrive at the point where it is possible to witness the arrival of the object? How is the arrival a form of witnessing in which “what arrives” becomes a “what” only in the event of being apprehended as a “what”?

At least two entities have to arrive to create an encounter, a “bringing forth” in the sense of an occupation. So, this table and Husserl have to “co-incide,” for him to write his philosophy about “the table.” The dash in “co-incidence” must be highlighted here to avoid turning the shared arrival into a matter of chance. To “co-incide” suggests how different things happen at the same moment, a happening that bring things near to other things, whereby the nearness shapes the shape of each thing. Simultaneous arrivals are not necessarily a matter of chance; arrivals are determined, at least in a certain way, as a determination that might determine what gets near, even if it does not decide what happens *once we are near*. If being near to this or that object is not a matter of chance, what happens in the “now” of this nearness remains open, in the sense that we don’t always know things affect each other, or how we will be affected by things (Deleuze 1992: 627).⁹

So, we can ask: How did the table arrive at the point, where Husserl could face the paper that is on it? How did he arrive at the table as the tool that “brings forth” his philosophy and is itself “brought forth” as the very materials on which his philosophy is written? How is the object, in Derrida’s term, an “arrivant”? For Derrida, the arrivant signifies the “perhaps” of the “what arrives?” As he puts it: “What is going to come, *perhaps*, is not only this or that; it is at last the thought of the *perhaps* itself. The *arrivant* will arrive *perhaps*, for one must never be sure when it comes to *arrive*; but the *arrivant* could also be the *perhaps* itself, the unheard of, totally new experience of the *perhaps*” (1997: 29, see also Derrida 1994b: 33–34). To say the object is an arrivant is to signal not only that it is nearby but also that its nearness is not simply given.

The “bringing forth” of the object involves, for sure, its arrival; in coming into being it comes “here,” near enough to me, or to you, as it must do if it is to be seen as this or that object. Nothing is not brought forth “without” coming to reside somewhere, where the somewhere (say, the house, the room, or the skin) shapes the surface of “what” it “is” that is brought forth. In “having arrived” how does the object become “what,” where “what” is open to the “perhaps” of the future?

Heidegger turns to the etymology of the object when he considers how the object “is” insofar as “it is thrown.” The word “thrown” risks turning the arrival of the object into an event, a happening, which is here insofar as it is “now.” Lefebvre offers a critique of Heidegger’s concept of “thrownness,” which understands production as “causing to appear” (1991: 122). I would also suggest that the arrival of an object does not just happen in a moment; it is not that the object “makes an appearance,” even though we can be thrown by an object’s appearance. An arrival takes time, and the time that it takes shapes “what” it is that arrives. The object could even be described as the transformation of time into form, which itself could be redefined as the “direction” of matter. What arrives not only depends on time, but is shaped by the conditions of its arrival, by how it came to get here. Think of a sticky object; what it picks up on its surface “shows” where it has traveled and what it has come into contact with. You bring your past encounters with you when you arrive. In this sense an arrival has not simply happened; an arrival points toward a future that might or “perhaps” will happen, given that we don’t always know in advance “what” we will come into contact with when we follow this or that line. At the same time, the arrival only becomes an arrival insofar as it has happened; and the object may “appear” only as an effect of work that has already taken place.

Our question could be reformulated as: What work goes into the making of things, such that they take form as this or that thing? Marxism provides a philosophy for rethinking the object as not only in history, but as an effect of history. The Marxian critique of German idealism begins after all with a critique of the idea that the object is “in the present,” or that the object is “before me.” As Marx and Engels put it, in their critique of Feuerbach:

He does not see how the sensuous world around him is, not a thing given direct from all eternity, remaining ever the same, but the product of industry, and of the state of society; and indeed, in the sense that it is a historical product, and the result of the activity of a whole succession of generations, each standing on

the shoulders of the preceding one, developing its industry and its intercourse, modifying its social system according to its changed needs. Even the objects of the simplest “sensuous certainty” are only given him through social demands, industry and commercial intercourse. The cherry-tree, like almost all fruit-trees, was, as is well known, only a few centuries ago transplanted by *commerce* into our zone, and therefore only *by* this action of a definite society in a definite age it has become “sensuous certainty” for Feuerbach. (1975: 170)

If phenomenologists were simply to “look at” the object that they face, then they would be erasing the “signs” of history. They would apprehend the object as simply there, as given in its sensuous certainty rather than as “having got here,” an arrival that is at once the way in which objects are binding and how they assume a social form. So objects (such as the cherry tree) are “transplanted.” They take the shape of a social action, which is forgotten in the givenness of the object. The temporality of “what comes before” is erased in the experience of the object as “what is before” in the spatial sense. For Marx and Engels, actions are generational and intergenerational (the point is not about individual action). What passes through history is not only the work done by generations, but the “sedimentation” of that work is the condition of arrival for future generations. Objects take the shape of this history; objects “have value” and they take shape through labor. They are formed out of labor, but they also “take the form” of that labor. What Marxism lets us do is to rearticulate the historicity of furniture, among other things.¹⁰ History cannot simply be perceived on the surface of the object, even if how objects surface or take shape is an effect of such histories. In other words, history cannot simply be turned into something that is given in its sensuous certainty, as if it could be a property of an object.

If idealism takes the object as given, then it fails to account for its conditions of arrival, which are not simply given. Idealism is the philosophical counterpart to what Marx would later describe as commodity fetishism. I want to suggest that it is not just commodities that are fetishized: objects that I perceive as objects, as having properties of their own, as it were, are produced through the process of fetishism. The object is “brought forth” as a thing that is “itself” only insofar as it is cut off from its own arrival. So it becomes that which we have presented to us, only if we forget how it arrived, as a history that involves multiple forms of contact between others. Objects appear by being cut off from such histories of arrival, as histories that involve multiple genera-

tions, and the “work” of bodies, which is of course the work of some bodies more than others.

Let us turn to Marx’s model of “commodity fetishism.” In *Capital* he suggests that commodities are made up of two elements, “matter and labour,” where labor is understood as “changing the form of matter” (1887: 50). The commodity is assumed to have value, or a life of its own, only if we forget the labor: “It becomes value only in its congealed state, when embodied in the form of some object” (57). The commodity, in other words, both transforms labor into an object and takes the very “form” of labor. Interestingly, Marx also uses the example of “the table” (although we don’t know what kind of table he refers to). He suggests that the table is made from wood (which provides, as it were, the matter), and that the work of the table—the work that it takes to “make the table”—changes the form of the wood, even though the table “is” still made out of wood. As he states: “It is as clear as noon-day that man, by his industry, changes the forms of the material furnished by nature in such a way as to make them useful to him. The form of wood, for instance, is altered by making a table out of it, for all that, the table continues to be that common every-day thing, wood. But, as soon as it steps forth as a commodity, it is changed into something transcendent” (76).

The Marxian critique of commodity fetishism notably relies here on a distinction between matter and form, between the wood and the table. The “becoming table” of the wood is not the same as its commodification. The table has use value, even after it has transformed the “form” of the wood. The table can be used, and in being used the value of the table is not exchanged and made abstract. The table has use value until it is exchanged. One problem with this model is that the dynamism of “making form” is located in the transformation of nature into use value: we could also suggest that the “wood” (nature/matter) has acquired its form over time. Nature then would not be simply “there,” waiting to be formed or to take form. Marx and Engel’s earlier critique of idealism involves a more dynamic view of the “facts of matter”: even the trees, which provide the wood, are themselves “brought forth” as effects of generational action. The wood is itself “formed matter” insofar as trees are not simply given but take shape as an effect of labor (“transplanted by commerce”).¹¹ The orientation of this table, how it appears as a table for work, depends on these multiple histories of labor, redefined as matter taking form.¹²

It is not surprising that Derrida offers a critique of the Marxian distinction

between use value and exchange value (1994a: 149), by turning toward the table. As he suggests: “The table is familiar, too familiar.” For Derrida, the table is not simply something we use: “The table has been worn down, exploited, overexploited, or else set aside and beside itself, no longer in use, in antique shops or auction rooms” (149). He thus suggests that “the table in use” is as metaphysical as “table as commodity”: use value as well as exchange value involves fetishism (162). While I agree with this argument, we might note that for Marx the table in use is not simply: it involves the “trans-formation” of matter into form. Use value is hence not a simple matter for Marx, even if he locates the transcendental in the “queer” commodity.¹³

What a Marxist approach could allow us to do, if we extend Marx’s critique of the commodity to the very matter of wood as well as the form of the table, is to consider the history of “what appears” and how it is shaped by histories of work. The commodity might be one moment in the “life history” or career of an object (Appadurai 1988: 17). The table as an object also moves around; it acquires new forms; it is put to different uses. For example, I buy the table (for this or that amount of money) as a table “for” writing. I have to bring it to the space where it will reside (the study, or the space marked out in a corner of another room). Others bring it for me: they transport the table. They bring it up the stairs. I wince as the edge of the table hits the wall, leaving a mark on both the wall and the table—which shows, too, what the table came into contact with during the time of its arrival. The table, having arrived, is nestled in the corner of the room. I use it as a writing desk. Having arrived, I turn to the table and sit on the chair which is placed alongside it. The chair allows me to reach the table, to cover it with my arms, and to write upon it. And yet, I am not sure what will happen to the table in the future. I could put the table to a different use (I could use it as a dining table if it is big enough “to support” this kind of action), or I could even forget about the table if I ceased to write, whereupon it might be “put aside” out of reach. The object is not reducible to the commodity, even when it is bought and sold: indeed, the object is not reducible to itself, which means it does not “have” an “itself” that is apart from its contact with others. The actions performed on the object (as well as with the object) shape the object. The object in turn affects what we do, as I will discuss in the section following.

Going back to the table, we would remember that the table was made by somebody; and that there is a history to its arrival, as a history of trans-

portation, which could be redescribed as a history of *changing hands*. As Igor Kopytoff puts it, we can have a cultural biography of things, which would show how “they are culturally redefined and put to use” (1988: 67).¹⁴ This table, you might say, has a story. What a story it could tell. What we need to recall is how the “thisness” of this table does not, as it were, belong to it: what is particular about this table, what we can tell through its biography, is also what allows us to tell a larger story: a story not only of “things” changing hands, but of how things come to matter by taking shape through and in the labor of others.¹⁵

Such histories are not simply available *on* the surface of the object, apart from the scratches that might be left behind. Histories shape “what” surfaces: they are behind the arrival of “the what” that surfaces. Histories are in this sense spectral; just like Husserl’s “missing sides.” We do not know, of course, the story of Husserl’s table, how it arrived, or what happened to the table after he stopped writing. But having arrived, we can follow what the table allowed him to do by reading his philosophy as a philosophy that turns to the table. So even if the “thisness” of the table disappears in his work, we could allow its “thisness” to reappear by making this table “matter” in our reading.

Doing Things

The object has arrived. And, having arrived, what then does it do? I want to suggest that objects not only are shaped by work, but that they also take the shape of the work they do. To think about how objects are “occupied” we can begin by considering how we are busy “with” them. Whether we “take” up different objects depends on how we are already occupied and on the kind of work that we do. We say that we occupy space; that we have an occupation. We are occupied with objects, which present themselves as tools to extend “the reach” of our actions. We are occupied when we are busy. We are booked up; we are using up time when we are occupied with something. We might be preoccupied by something, which means we don’t notice something else. The word “occupy” allows us to link the question of inhabiting or residing within space; to work, or even to having an identity through work (an occupation); to time (to be occupied with); to holding something; and to taking possession of something *as* a thing. How are we occupied with objects? How does an occupation orientate us toward some objects and, in that towardness, to some ways of living over others? How does this orientation take up time as well as space?

It is no accident that Heidegger poses this question of occupation, of what it is that we do, by turning to the table. In *Ontology: The Hermeneutics of Facticity* (1999),¹⁶ Heidegger contrasts two ways of describing tables. In the first model, the table is encountered as “a thing in space—as a spatial thing” (68). Although Heidegger evokes Husserl’s description of “the table,” Husserl is not named, or at least not at this point. As Heidegger states: “Aspects show themselves and open up in ever new ways as we walk around the thing” (68). Heidegger suggests that this description is inaccurate not because it is false (the table might after all appear in this way) but because it does not describe how the significance of such things is not simply “in” the thing, but rather a “characteristic of being” (67–68). For Heidegger what makes “the table” what it is, and not something else, is what the table allows us to do.

The words by Heidegger that follow form one of the richest phenomenological descriptions of the table as it is experienced from the points of view of those who share the space of its dwelling: “What is there in *the* room there at home is *the* table (not ‘a’ table among many other tables in other rooms and houses) at which one sits *in order to* write, have a meal, sew, or play. Everyone sees this right away, e.g. during a visit: it is a writing table, a dining table, a sewing table—such is the primary way in which it is being encountered in itself. This characteristic of ‘in order to do something’ is not merely imposed on the table by relating and assimilating it to something else which it is not” (69).¹⁷ In other words, what we do with the table, or what the table allows us to do, is essential to the table. The table provides a surface around which a family gathers: Heidegger describes his wife sitting at the table and reading, and “the boys” busying themselves at the table.¹⁸ The “in order to” structure of the table, in other words, means that the people who are “at” the table are also part of what makes the table itself. Doing things “at” the table is what makes the table what it is and not some other thing.

We could perhaps then redescribe the table as a tool, as something we do something with. In *Being and Time* Heidegger offers us a powerful reading of tools as he does in his later work on technology. In the former, Heidegger considers the “pragmatic” character of things, which is obscured by the presentation of things as “mere things,” and he considers such things as forms of equipment. As he suggests, “In our dealings, we come across equipment for writing, sewing, working, transportation” (1973: 97). In ordering his phenomenology around equipment, Heidegger departs from Husserl by suggesting that the pragmatic orientation of things is associated within their being, or what he

describes as the “equipmentality” of objects. Equipmentality is about what “things” or “objects” allow bodies to do: they have an “in-order-to” structure, which assigns or refers to something. So what makes the object “itself” is what it allows us to do, and that “doing” takes the object out of itself and makes it “point” toward something, whether that something is an action or other objects. So the writing table is Husserl’s equipment: it “points toward” writing as well as to other objects, which gather around writing as tools that allow this kind of work: the inkwell, pencils, and so on. The writing table might also point toward the writing body, as that which becomes “itself” once it “takes up” the equipment and “takes up” time and space, in doing the work that the equipment allows the body to do.

What objects do is what brings them forth in the shape they have. The wheel can roll, the desk can hold a computer, the pen can write, the jug can pour. The use of “can” here might help remind us that “usefulness” is not merely instrumental but is about capacities that are open to the future. The capacity is not so much “in” the tool, but depends on how the tool is taken up or “put to use.” Heidegger makes exactly this point in his later work on technology. It is not just that the object tends toward something, where the tendency supports an action, but that the shape of the object is itself shaped by the work for which it is intended. For Heidegger, the thing “is not merely an aggregate of traits, nor an accumulation of properties by which the aggregate arises,” rather it “is that around which the properties have been assembled” (1975: 22–23). We can see in this model of property as assemblage, how the thing becomes something that “has” properties. The thing would be a thing insofar as it is being used as the thing that it was brought into the world to be: “The peasant woman wears her shoes in the field. *Only here are they what they are*” (33).

Technology does not simply refer to objects that we use to extend capacities for action. Technology (or *techne*) becomes instead the process of “bringing forth” or, as Heidegger states, “to make something appear, within what is present, as this or as that, in this way or that way” (159). The object is an effect of “bringing forth,” where the “bringing forth” is a question of the determination of form: the object itself has been shaped for something, *which means it takes the shape of what it is for*. The object is not just material, although it is material: the object is matter given some form or another where the form “intends” toward something. The table has a horizontal surface, which “supports” the action for which it is intended. This “tending toward” is what

shapes its form, which then allows us to recognize the object as this object and not another. Form takes shape through the “direction” of matter toward an action. So we do things “on the table,” which is what makes the table what it is and take shape in the way that it does. *The table is assembled around the “support” it gives.*

And yet, objects do not only do what we intend them to do. Heidegger differentiates between using something and perceiving something, which he describes in terms of grasping that something thematically (98). The example he uses is the hammer. When the hammer hammers, then it is “ready-to-hand.” The nearness of the hammer, the fact that it is available to me, is linked to its usefulness; it is near as it enables me to perform a specific kind of work. Such “ready-to-hand-ness” is interesting to Heidegger, insofar as it is something to do with what the hammer “is.” Indeed, Heidegger suggests that the object as practice, as something we do something with, involves “*its own kind of sight*” (99) which is a different sight than looking at the hammer as if it were not something that simply hammered. Heidegger thus suggests that when the ready-to-hand is not “handy,” we see it differently; it becomes “present-to-hand.” So the hammer breaks, and it is not that I no longer see what the object really is (for it “is” a hammer), but that I see it in a different way, as something that does not move toward something: “When equipment cannot be used, this implies the constitutive assignment of the ‘in-order-to’ to a ‘toward-this’ has been disturbed . . . But when an assignment has been disturbed—when something is unusable for some purpose—then the assignment becomes explicit” (105). What difference does this “making explicit” make? Heidegger moves on:

The entity which is held in our fore-having—for instance, the hammer—is proximally ready-to-hand as equipment. If this entity becomes the “object” of an assertion, then as soon as we begin this assertion, there is already a change over in the fore-having. Something *ready-to-hand with which* we have to do or perform something, turns into something “*about which*” the assertion that points it out is made. Our fore-sight is aimed at something present-to-hand in what is ready-to-hand. Both *by* and *for* this way of looking at it [*Hin-sicht*], the ready-to-hand becomes veiled as ready-to-hand. Within this discovering of presence-at-hand, which is at the same time a covering up of readiness-to-hand, something present-at-hand which we encounter is given a definite character in its Being-present-at-hand-in-such-and-such-a-manner. Only now are we given any access to *properties* or the like. (200)

So it is when the hammer is broken, or when I cannot use it, that I become aware of the hammer as an object-in-itself, rather than as object, which refers beyond itself to an action that I intend to perform. So at this moment of “failure” the hammer is perceived as having properties; as being, for instance, “too heavy.” The hammer ceases to be a means to do something (where the object is the action) and becomes the object that we attend to, or are concerned with. While this model does not designate the usefulness of objects, and their familiarity as functional things as “the natural attitude,” which must be bracketed by phenomenology, it does distinguish between using something and perceiving something, although use is given its own kind of sight.

What is being revealed when technologies are no longer ready for action? For Heidegger, it is properties that are revealed. He suggests that when the hammer ceases to hammer, that is, we cease to be able to hammer with it, then we become aware of it as having a specific form: “The hammer is too heavy.” In other words, we only feel the heaviness of the hammer at the moment in which we cannot use the hammer to perform the action: when the hammer does not hammer. But clearly this propositional statement about the hammer—“The hammer is too heavy”—is still a statement that “points” toward what the hammer “should” do. In other words, the heaviness of the hammer *still refers to the action that the hammer itself directs us toward*. The hammer is too heavy for what? It is too heavy to hammer “with,” after all. The “too heavy” suggests that the hammer does not allow me to hammer. The judgment about the hammer, which gives it a property as being this or that kind of thing, still perceives the hammer in terms of what it can or should do, even in the moment of the failure of the hammer to perform its action.

So when something is no longer ready for action it does follow that we have access to its properties, as if they are independent of the histories of action that bring such objects forth, as the “what” that is near. This is not to say that it does not make a difference to how we perceive things when those things are and are not “put to use.” Rather, it is to say that the failure of things to be put to use does not mean an access to properties of things that are independent of their use. Indeed, we might want to question the presumption that things have properties, which do not point toward their “assignment” in a familiar and social order.

So what does it mean to say that an object fails to do the work for which it was intended? This failure might not simply be a question of the object itself

failing. For the hammer might be too heavy for you to use but perfectly adequate for me. A hammer might be broken and not enable me to do one thing, but it could still let me do something else. Failure, which is about the loss of the capacity to perform an action for which the object was intended is not a property of an object (though it tends to be attributed in this way and there is no doubt that *things can go wrong*), but rather of the failure of an object to extend a body, which we can define in terms of the extension of bodily capacities to perform actions. The body cannot extend itself through the object in a way that was intended, although of course “intention” should not then become a presumed property of things (a child who picks up the broken hammer and begins to play a game is still doing something). The experience of this “nonextension” might then lead to “the object” *being attributed* with properties, qualities and values. In other words, what is at stake in moments of failure is not so much access to properties but attributions of properties, which become a matter of how we *approach* the object. So if I state, “The hammer is too heavy,” then I mean, “The hammer is too heavy for me to hammer with.” The moment of “non-use” is the moment in which the object is attributed as having properties, and it is the same moment in which objects may be judged insofar as they are inadequate to a task, the moment when we “blame the tool.”¹⁹

Let us return now to the table. The table has a certain form, as we know. It is made of something (perhaps wood). The matter and the form of the table are dependent on histories of labor, which are congealed in and as the very “thing” of the table. The table is an effect of work, and it also points to work in the very form that it takes. Different tables have different functions: we do things with them by performing actions upon them. If our object is a writing table, then our table is specifically adapted for convenience in writing or reading, perhaps something made with a sloping top and generally fitted drawer and compartments. The word table, we might note, is derived from the Latin *tabula*, which primarily means a “board,” especially one used for games or for writing. In its earliest English usages, “table” meant a “surface,” in particular a “surface for writing,” before the “table” became the name of the familiar article of furniture that we could describe as an “object with a horizontal surface.” The shape of the table depends at least to some extent on what it allows us to do: the horizontal surface should be at the height appropriate for its work. The writing table is higher than the coffee table, for instance, as a

difference determined in part by function, or by what each table is being asked to do. A coffee table at the height of my waist would amount to a failed orientation, as I could not extend myself through it, by using it as something on which to place my coffee cup while I am sitting down on the sofa. The table is both an effect of work and also what allows us to work: whether the table “works” depends upon whether we can do, when we make use of the table, the work we intend to do.

The failure of objects to work could be described as a question of fit: it would be the failure of subjects and objects to work together. So the appropriateness of the height of the table is itself dependent on the body that uses it: Husserl’s table could be too high or too low for me, depending on our differences of height. Husserl’s writing table would work for him only if it were placed in a way that enabled him to write. If this table does not work for me, I would “turn toward” it a different way. I might then attribute my failure to write to the table, such that it becomes the cause of the failure. Such a turning would be felt as a frustration, through which the table might be perceived as “too this or too that,” or even as a bad object. The perception of the object as having qualities is not then a perception of what is proper to the object. The failure would be the failure of the object to enable the action with which it is identified. The table is “too high,” which means I cannot write at the table: the “tooness” refers not to the table’s presence for itself but to how it is or is not ready for me.

I am not suggesting here that the objects do not have properties that may be revealed when they are put into action (a “putting into” that can also involve the failure to act). Objects do have qualities that make them tangible in the present. But these characteristics are not simply “in” the objects but instead are about how the objects work and are worked on by others. The example of the hammer that is too heavy or the table that is too high shows us how the position of the object, and indeed the qualities perceived in an object as given, refer us to the relations between objects and the subjects that make use of them. This does not vacate or empty the object as “just” a vehicle for subjects. Those qualities only come to matter in terms of how the objects and subjects work together; they cannot be assigned to the subject or object, although in everyday experience such assignments do happen. Failure can of course be attributed to subjects as well as to objects: the subject can turn away from the object and toward itself. I could say, for example, I am too short for this table,

as well as this table is too high for me. To orientate oneself can mean to adjust one's position, or another's position, such that we are "facing" the right direction: we know where we are through how we position ourselves in relation to others. Work also involves adjustments: we might move this way or that, so we can work with this or that object: work involves a direction toward the object, which then works for us. The failure of work is not, then, "in" the thing or "in" the person but rather is about whether the person and the thing face each other *in the right way*.

When things are orientated they are facing the right way: in other words, the objects around the body allow the body itself to be extended. When things are orientated, we are occupied and busy. The "point" of this occupation might even make the face of the object recede from view. Occupation is hence not just about "any body," for an object tends toward some bodies more than others, depending on "the tendencies" of bodies. Objects may even take the shape of the bodies for whom they are "intended," in what it is that they allow a body to do. The writing table thus "tends toward" the writer. An action is possible when the body and the object "fit." So it is not simply that some bodies and tools *happen* to generate specific actions. Objects, as well as spaces, are made for some kinds of bodies more than others. Objects are made to size as well as made to order: while they come in a range of sizes, the sizes also presume certain kinds of bodies as having "sizes" that will "match." In this way, bodies and their objects tend toward each other; they are orientated toward each other, and are shaped by this orientation. When orientation "works," we are occupied. The failure of something to work is a matter of a *failed orientation*: a tool is used by a body for which it was not intended, or a body uses a tool that does not extend its capacity for action.

Inhabiting Spaces

How do bodies "matter" in what objects do? To consider this question we can return to the table. We already know how Husserl's attention wanders: from the writing table and only then toward other spaces: the darkness of the unseen portions of the room. What he sees is shaped by a direction he has already taken, a direction that shapes what is available to him in the sense of what he faces and what he can reach. What he faces also shapes what is behind him, and what is available as the background to his vision. So his gaze might fall on

the paper, which is on the table, given that he is sitting at the desk, the writing table, and not at another kind of table, such as the kitchen table. Such other tables would not, perhaps, be the “right” kind of tables for the making of philosophy. The writing table might be the table “for him,” the one that would provide the right kind of horizontal surface for the philosopher. Such a table in turn would face him; as the writing table it would face the one who writes. There are also objects that gather around the scene of writing, as “would be” tools of the philosopher, and these objects are “within sight” for the philosopher, and perhaps must be, if philosophy is to endure. So the philosopher faces these objects, more than others, in the labor of doing philosophy, even if the approach taken makes the objects disappear.

I have suggested that the orientation of objects is shaped by what objects allow me to do. In this way an object is what an action is directed toward. In this section, I want to consider how actions take place in space. Clearly, action depends on the object being near enough: “I see it only if it is within the radius of my action” (Merleau-Ponty 1968: 7). At the same time, while objects have to be near enough to complete specific actions, such actions are what bring objects near to me. So, you can only write on the writing table if the table is within reach, but the reachability of the table might be an effect of what you already do for a living. It exists for you insofar as it is near. In other words, the nearness of certain objects is an effect of the work the body does, and the work the body does is what makes certain objects near. Action depends on how we reside in space with objects: what Husserl was to call in his later work, “the near sphere” and the “core sphere” as “the sphere of things which I can reach” (2002: 149).

The relation between action and space is hence crucial. It is not simply that we act in space; spatial relations between subjects and others are produced through actions, which make some things available to be reached. Or, as Lefebvre suggests: “Activity in space is restricted by that space; space ‘decides’ what actually may occur, but even this ‘decision’ has limits placed upon it” (1991: 143). So the space of the study is shaped by a decision (that this room is *for* this kind of work), which itself then “shapes” what actions “happen” in that space. The question of action is a question then of how we inhabit space. Given this, action involves the intimate co-dwelling of bodies and objects. This is not to say that bodies are simply objects alongside other objects. As Merleau-Ponty shows us, bodies are “not the same” as other kinds of objects

precisely given their different relation to space. The body, he suggests, is “no longer merely an object in the world,” rather “it is our point of view in the world” (1964: 5). Returning to Husserl’s table, we can consider how the body moves around the object; and that very motility is remarkable in its difference from *that which it moves around*. As Merleau-Ponty suggests: “We grasp external spaces through our bodily situation. A ‘corporeal’ or postural schema gives us a global, practical and implicit notion of the relation between our body and things, and our hold on them. A system of possible movements, or ‘motor projects’ radiates from us to the environment. Our body is not in space like things; it inhabits or haunts space. It implies itself to space like a hand to an instrument and when we wish to move about we do not move the body as we move an object” (5).

The language here implies that bodies provide us with a tool, as that through which we “hold” or “grasp” onto things, but elsewhere Merleau-Ponty suggests that the body is not itself an instrument but a form of expression, a making visible of our intentions (1964: 5). What makes bodies different is how they inhabit space: space is not a container for the body; it does not contain the body as if the body were “in it.” Rather bodies are submerged, such that they become the space they inhabit; in taking up space, bodies move through space and are affected by the “where” of that movement. It is through this movement that the surface of spaces as well as bodies takes shape. Recalling Husserl, his encounter with the table involves moving around it. Of course, bodies are not the only kinds of objects that move. But when they move, we move. The table would become available to me, within my reach, only insofar as my bodily posture orientates me toward it and even spreads over it. The profile of the table is shaped by the profile of the body, even if that profile “disappears” from view.

Of course, when Husserl “grasps” his table from the series of impressions, as being more than what he sees at any point in time, it is his “eyes” that are doing the work: he “closes his eyes” and “opens his eyes” (1969: 130). The object’s partiality is seen, even if the object is unavailable in a single sight. Interestingly, in the second volume of *Ideas* Husserl attends to the lived body (*Leib*) and to the intimacy of touch.²⁰ The table returns, as we would expect. And yet, what a different table we find if we reach for it differently. In this moment, it is the hands rather than the eyes that reach the table: “My hand is lying on the table. I experience the table as something solid, cold,

smooth" (1989: 153). Husserl conveys the proximity between bodies and objects as "things" that become more than "matter" insofar as they can be sensed and touched; insofar as they make impressions. Bodies are "something touching which is touched" (155). The locations of sensation on the skin surface shows that the sensation is not "in" the object or the body but instead takes shape as an effect of their encounter. As Rosalyn Diprose suggests, the world described by phenomenology is an "interworld," or an "open circuit" between the perceiving body and its world (2002: 102).

Phenomenology hence shows how objects and others have already left their impressions on the skin surface. The tactile object is what is near me, or what is within my reach. In being touched, the object does not "stand apart"; it is felt "by" the skin and even "on" the skin. In other words, we perceive the object as an object, as something that "has" integrity, and is "in" space, only by haunting that very space; that is, by co-inhabiting space such that the boundary between the co-inhabitants of space does not hold. The skin connects as well as contains. The nonopposition between the bodies that move around objects, and objects around which bodies move, shows us how orientations involve at least a two-way "approach," or the "more than one" of an encounter.²¹ Orientations are tactile and they involve more than one skin surface: we, in approaching this or that table, are also approached by the table, which touches us when we touch it. As Husserl shows us, the table might be cold and smooth and the quality of its surface can only be felt once I have ceased to stand apart from it. This body with this table is a different body than it would be without it. And, the table is a different table when it is with me than it would be without me. Neither the object nor the body have integrity in the sense of being "the same thing" with and without others. Bodies as well as objects take shape through being orientated toward each other, as an orientation that may be experienced as the co-habitation or sharing of space.²²

Bodies are hence shaped by contact with objects and with others, with "what" is near enough to be reached. Bodies may even take shape through such contact, or take the shape of that contact. What gets near is both shaped by what bodies do, which in turn affects what bodies can do. Paul Schilder's work on body image places an emphasis on how bodies are shaped by what is and is not brought near to them. As he suggests: "The space around the body-image may either bring the objects nearer to the body or the body nearer to the objects. The emotional configuration determines the distance of objects from

the body” (1950: 216). Bringing objects near to bodies, which also brings bodies near to objects, involves acts of perception about “what” can be brought near to me. For instance, the nearness of the philosopher to his paper, his ink, and his table is not simply about “where” he does his work and the spaces he inhabits, as if the “where” could be separated from “what” he does. The nearness of such objects is required by his work, which is also “what” he does for a living. So the objects are near as the instruments of philosophy, which shape the kind of body that philosophy acquires as well as the body of the philosopher.

We can continue with the example of the table. As an object it also provides a space, which itself is the space for action, for certain kinds of work. As we know, Husserl’s table in the first volume of *Ideas* is the writing table, and his orientation toward this table, and not others, shows the orientation of his philosophy, even at the very moment that “this” table disappears.²³ Around the table a horizon or fringe of perception is “dimly” apprehended. When Husserl writes, the writing table itself may only be dimly perceived. The horizon is what is “around” as the body does its work. As Don Ihde notes: “Horizons belong to the boundaries of the experienced environmental field. Like the ‘edges’ of the visual field, they situate what is explicitly present, while in phenomena itself, horizons recede” (1990: 114). The horizon is not an object that I apprehend: I do not see it. The horizon is what gives objects their contours, and it even allows such objects to be reached. Objects are objects insofar as they are within my horizon; it is in the act of reaching “toward them” that makes them available as objects for me. The bodily horizon shows what bodies can reach toward by establishing a line beyond which they cannot reach; the horizon marks the edge of what can be reached by the body. The body becomes present as a body, with surfaces and boundaries, in showing the “limits” of what it can do.

We might think that we reach for whatever comes into view. And yet, what “comes into” view, or what is within our horizon, is not a matter simply of what we find here or there, or even where we find ourselves as we move here or there. What is reachable is determined precisely by orientations that we have already taken. Some objects don’t even become objects of perception, as the body does not move toward them: they are “beyond the horizon” of the body, and thus out of reach. The surfaces of bodies are shaped by what is reachable. Indeed, the history of bodies can be rewritten as the history of the reachable.

Orientations are about the direction we take that puts some things and not others in our reach. So the object, which is apprehending only by exceeding my gaze, can be apprehended only insofar as it has come to be available to me: its reachability is not simply a matter of its place or location (the white paper on the table, for instance), but instead is shaped by the orientations I have taken that mean I face some ways more than others (toward this kind of table, which marks out the space I tend to inhabit).

Phenomenology helps us to explore how bodies are shaped by histories, which they perform in their comportment, their posture, and their gestures. Both Husserl and Merleau-Ponty, after all, describe bodily horizons as “sedimented histories” (see Steinbock 1995: 36). This model of history as bodily sedimentation has been taken up by social theorists; for Pierre Bourdieu, for example, such histories are described as the *habitus*, as “systems of durable, transposable, dispositions” (1977: 72) which integrate past experiences through the very “*matrix of perceptions, appreciations and actions*” that are necessary to accomplish “infinitely diversified tasks” (83).²⁴ For Judith Butler, it is precisely how phenomenology exposes the “sedimentation” of history in the repetition of bodily action, that makes it a useful resource for feminism (1997a: 406). What bodies “tend to do” are effects of histories rather than being originary.

We could say that history “happens” in the very repetition of gestures, which is what gives bodies their tendencies. We might note here that the labor of such repetition disappears through labor: if we work hard at something, then it seems “effortless.” This paradox—with effort it becomes effortless—is precisely what makes history disappear in the moment of its enactment. The repetition of the work is what makes the work disappear. It is important that we think not only about *what* is repeated, but also about how the repetition of actions takes us in certain directions: we are also orientating ourselves toward some objects more than others, including not only physical objects (the different kinds of tables) but also objects of thought, feeling, and judgment, as well as objects in the sense of aims, aspirations, and objectives. I might “orientate” myself around writing, for instance, not simply as a certain kind of work (although it is that, and it requires certain objects for it to be possible), but also as a goal: writing becomes something that I aspire to, even as an identity (becoming a writer). So the object we aim for, *which we have in our view*, also comes into our view through being held in place as that we seek to be: the action searches for identity as the mark of attainment (the writer “becomes” a

writer through the work of writing). We can ask what kinds of objects bodies “tend toward” in their tendencies, as well as how such tendencies shape what bodies tend toward.

Of course, I too am working on a table, though for me the kitchen table as much as the writing table provides the setting for action: for cooking, eating, as well as writing. I have a study space and I work on a table in that space. As I type this now, I am using a keyboard placed on a computer table that resides in the study, which as noted above is a space that has been set aside for this kind of work. This particular table is designed for the computer, and for working on the computer. I fit into this space in a certain way by sitting on the chair, which is before the table. Objects and bodies “work together” as spaces for action; so here I type as I face this object, and it is what I am working on. I am touching the object, as well as the keyboard, and I am aware of it, as a sensuous given that is available for me. In repeating the work of typing, my body also feels a certain way. My neck gets sore, and I stretch to ease the discomfort. I pull my shoulders back every now and then as the posture I assume (a bad posture I am sure) is a huddle: I huddle over the table as I repeat the action (the banging of keys with the tips of my fingers); the action shapes me and leaves its impression, through bodily sensations, prickly feelings on the skin surface, and the more intense experience of discomfort. I write, and in performing this work I might yet become my object—become a writer, with a writer’s body, and a writer’s tendencies (the sore neck, the sore shoulders, are sure signs of having done this kind of work).

Repetitive strain injury (RSI) can be understood as the effect of such repetition: we repeat some actions, sometimes over and over again, and this is partly about the nature of the work we might do. Our body takes the shape of this repetition; *we get stuck in certain alignments as an effect of this work*. For instance, my right ring finger has acquired the shape of its own work: the constant use of a pen, in writing, has created a lump, which is the shape that is shaped by the work of this repetition; my finger almost looks “as if” it has the shape of a pen as an impression upon it. The object on which and through which I work hence leaves its impression: the action, as intending, as well as tending toward the object, shapes my body in this way and that. The work of repetition is not neutral work; *it orients the body in some ways rather than others*. The lump on my finger is a sure sign of an orientation I have taken, not just toward the pen-object, or the keyboard, but also toward the world, as someone

who does a certain kind of work for a living. Husserl's writing also "shows" his orientation: the tables that appear first are the writing tables, as proper objects of philosophy, which itself is shaped by the orientations taken toward its objects, as objects of thought. Orientations shape what bodies do, while bodies are shaped by orientations they already have, as effects of the work that must take place for a body to arrive where it does.

Bodies hence acquire orientation through the repetitions of some actions over others, as actions that have certain "objects" in view, whether they are physical objects required to do the work (the writing table, the pen, the keyboard) or the ideal objects that one identifies with. The nearness of such objects, their availability within my bodily horizon, is not casual: *it is not just that I find them there, like that*. Rather, the nearness of such objects is a sign of an orientation I have already taken toward the world as an orientation that shapes what we call, inadequately, "character." Bodies tend toward some objects more than others given their tendencies. These tendencies are not ordinary but instead are effects of the repetition of the "tending toward." I will discuss in the next chapter the paradoxical temporality of such tendencies in relation to sexual orientation; here it will suffice to say that it makes sense to consider how bodies come to "have" certain orientations over time and that they come to be shaped by taking some directions rather than others and toward some objects rather than others.

The field of positive action, of what this or that body does do, also defines a field of inaction, of actions that are possible but that are not taken up, or even actions that are not possible because of what has been taken up. Such histories of action or "take up" shape the bodily horizon of bodies. Spaces are not only inhabited by bodies that "do things," but what bodies "do" leads them to inhabit some spaces more than others. If spaces extend bodies, then we could say that spaces also extend the shape of the bodies that "tend" to inhabit them. So, for instance, if the action of writing is associated with the masculine body, then it is this body that tends to inhabit the space for writing. The space for writing—say, the study—then tends to extend such bodies and may even take their shape. Gender becomes naturalized as a property of bodies, objects, and spaces partly through the "loop" of this repetition, which leads bodies in some directions more than others as if that direction came from within the body and explains which way it turns.

Here again we can return to the table—to the writing table, more specifi-

cally. In a way, the writing table waits for the body of the writer. In waiting for the writer the table waits for some bodies more than others. This waiting “orientates” the table to a specific kind of body, the body that would “take up” writing. I have already described such a body as a masculine body by evoking the gendered form of its occupation. Now, clearly, gender is not “in” the table or necessarily “in” the body that turns to the table. Gender is an effect of how bodies take up objects, which involves how they occupy space by being occupied in one way or another. We might note, for instance, in Heidegger’s *Ontology* (1999) that the table as a thing on which we do things allows for different ways of being occupied. So Heidegger writes on the table, his wife sews, and his children play. What we do on the table is also about being given a place within a familiar order (as I explore in the next chapter). Bodies are shaped by the work they do on the table, where work involves gendered forms of occupation.

In light of this we can consider Charlotte Perkin Gilman’s work on the “home,” where she speaks of the shaping of women’s bodies through how they inhabit domestic interiors. As she notes: “See it in furnishing. A stone or block of wood to sit on, a hide to lie on, a shelf to put the food on. See that block of wood change under your eyes and crawl up history on its forthcoming legs—a stool, a chair, a sofa, a settee, and now the endless ranks of sittable furniture wherewith we fill the home to keep ourselves from the floor withal . . . If you are confined at home you cannot walk much—therefore you must sit—especially if your task is a stationary one. So, to the home-bound woman came much sitting, and much sitting called for ever softer seats” (2002: 27–28). Gilman is writing here specifically about furnishings in the Orient, and she contrasts the soft bodies and chairs of this imagined interior with the domestic interiors in the West, which give women more mobility. I will take up the matter of orientalism in chapter 3; suffice to say here that Gilman shows us how orientations involve inhabiting certain bodily positions: sitting, walking, lying down, and so on. Such forms of occupation or of being occupied shape the furniture: the chairs become soft to provide seating for the body that sits. In turn, the body becomes soft as it occupies the soft seat, taking up the space made available by the seat. Such positions become habitual: they are repeated, and in being repeated they shape the body and what it can do. The more the body sits, the more it tends to be seated.

The point is simple: what we “do do” affects what we “can do.” This is not

to argue that “doing” simply restricts capacities. In contrast, what we “do do” opens up and expands some capacities, as an “expansion” in certain directions that in turn might restrict what you can do in others. A case in point would be “handedness”: the more we use one side of the body, the harder it is to use the other side. As Robert Hertz suggests, the cultural preference for the right side means that the “left hand is repressed and kept inactive” (1973: 5) and the right hand is given “more intensive work,” which “favours its development” (4). We acquire our tendencies as an effect of the direction of energy to this or that side. The more we work certain parts of the body, such as this or that muscle, the more work they can do. At the same time, the less we work other muscles, then the less they can do. So if gender shapes what we “do do,” then it shapes what we can do. Gender could thus be described as a bodily orientation, a way in which bodies get directed by their actions over time.

It is worth noting here that Iris Marion Young’s phenomenological model of female embodiment places a key emphasis on the role of orientation. Indeed, Young argues that gender differences *are* differences in orientation. As she suggests, “even in the most simple body orientations of men and women as they sit, stand, and walk, we can observe a typical difference in body style and extension” (2005: 32). This is not to say that orientations are themselves simply given, or that they “cause” such differences. Rather, orientations are both an effect of such differences as well as a mechanism for their reproduction. Young suggests that women have an “inhibited intentionality” in part because they do not get behind their bodies, as women see their bodies as “objects” as well as “capacities” (35). So becoming a woman means “throwing like a girl.” Women may throw objects, and are thrown by objects, in such a way that they take up less space. To put it simply, we acquire the shape of how we throw, as well as what we do. Or as Linda McDowell and Jo Sharpe suggest: “The body, its size, shape, gestures, the very space it takes up, those masculine and feminine norms which mean that men sprawl and women don’t; the differences in physicality that construct and reflect gender norms create ways of being in space” (1997: 203).

Gender is an effect of the kinds of work that bodies do, which in turn “directs” those bodies, affecting what they “can do.” At the same time, it is not always decided which bodies inhabit which spaces, even when spaces extend the form of some bodies and not others. Julia Wardhaugh argues that there is an increasing “recognition that rooms or spaces in the family home are not

effectively gendered even when they are designed to meet the requirements of men or women (for example, the height of kitchen benches). Rather it is the activities that are performed in these spaces at given times and in given relationship contexts that reflect and/or subvert ideas about gender” (1999: 92). In other words, even if what we “do do” affects what we “can do,” other things remain possible. For instance, bodies can take up spaces that do not extend their shape, which can in turn work to “reorientate” bodies and space. In the following two chapters I will discuss failed orientations as the “queer effect” of oblique or diagonal lines, created by bodies out of place. Here I wish simply to say that when women write, when they take up space as writers, their bodies in turn acquire new shapes, even if the effect is no longer quite so queer.

As Virginia Woolf shows us in *A Room of One's Own*, for women to claim a space to write is a political act. Of course, there are women who write. We know this. Women have taken up spaces orientated toward writing. And yet, the woman writer remains just that: the woman writer, deviating from the somatic norm of “the writer,” as such. We know too that there are women philosophers, and how they still cause trouble as “bodies out of place” in the “home” of philosophy, which itself is shaped by taking some bodies and not others as its somatic norm (Alcoff 1999). So what happens when the woman philosopher takes up her pen? What happens when the study is not reproduced as a masculine domain by the collective repetition of such moments of deviation?

Tables might even appear differently if we follow such moments of deviation and the lines they create. For Virginia Woolf, the table appears with her writing on it, as a feminist message inscribed on paper: “I must ask you to imagine a room, like many thousands, with a window looking across people’s hats and vans and motor-cars to other windows, and on the table inside the room a blank sheet of paper on which was written in large letters Women and Fiction and no more” (1991: 24). The table is not simply what Woolf faces but is also the “site” upon which she makes her feminist point: that we cannot address the question of women and fiction without asking the prior question of whether women have space to write. It is worth recalling here the feminist publisher named Kitchen Table press. We could say that the kitchen table provides the kind of surface on which women tend to work. To use the table that supports domestic work to do political work (including the work that makes explicit the politics of domestic work) is a reorientation device. The

kitchen table supports feminist writing, and feminist books appear under its name.

If making a feminist point returns us to the table, then the terms of its appearance will be different. It might be that quite a different table comes into view. In Iris Marion Young's *On Female Body Experience* the table arrives into her writing in the following way: "The nick on the table here happened during that argument with my daughter" (2005: 159). Here, the table records the intimacy of the relationship between mother and daughter; such intimacies, as the surfacing of conflict, are neither "put to one side" nor take place "on another side" of the table.²⁵ Tables for feminist philosophers might not bracket or put aside the intimacy of familial attachments; such intimacies are at the front; they are "on the table" rather than behind it. We might even say that feminist tables are shaped by such attachments; such attachments shape the surface of tables and how tables surface in feminist writing.

Of course, the woman philosopher still has to arrive, to get near enough to the writing table. It takes time, this arrival into the "scene" of writing, just as it takes time and work to keep one's attention on the writing table. Such an arrival is dependent on contact with others, and even *access* to the "occupation of writing," which itself is shaped by political economies as well as personal biographies. And yet, she arrives.²⁶ Having arrived, she might do a different kind of work given that she may not put these other attachments "behind" her.

So, yes, we can remember that some spaces are already occupied. They even take the shape of the bodies that occupy them. Bodies also take the shape of the spaces they occupy and of the work they do. And yet sometimes we reach what is not expected. A space, however occupied, is taken up by somebody else. When bodies take up spaces that they were not intended to inhabit, something other than the reproduction of the facts of the matter happens. The hope that reproduction fails is the hope for new impressions, for new lines to emerge, new objects, or even new bodies, which gather, in gathering around this table. The "new" would not involve the loss of the background. Indeed, for bodies to arrive in spaces where they are not already at home, where they are not "in place," involves hard work; indeed, it involves painstaking labor for bodies to inhabit spaces that do not extend their shape. Having arrived, such bodies in turn might acquire new shapes. And spaces in turn acquire new bodies. So, yes, we should celebrate such arrivals. The "new" is what is possible when what is behind us, our background, does not simply ground us or keep us

in place, but allows us to move and allows us to follow something other than the lines that we have already taken. Yes, women philosophers do gather and have gathered, creating their impressions. Our task is to recall their histories of their arrival, and how this history opens up spaces for others that have yet to be cleared.

The background to the object, which allows it to be put to work, depends upon work that is repeated over time that is often “hidden from view.” Perhaps where Husserl’s gaze fails to wander is into other spaces, such as the space of the kitchen—that is, as spaces that are often associated with the “work” that tends toward the body in terms of caring for it and sustaining it. Does Husserl’s gaze avoid wandering there insofar as those spaces are shaped by concealed labor; as the labor that gives him the capacity to “think” about the writing table? In a way, a queer phenomenology is involved in the project of “turning the tables” on phenomenology by turning toward other kinds of tables. Turning the tables would also allow us to return, a loving return we might even say, to the objects that already appear within phenomenology, such as Husserl’s table, now so worn. Such tables, when turned, would come to life as something to think “with” as well as “on.”

What lines, we might ask, will cover the page when the woman philosopher inhabits the space by the writing table and takes up her pen? And, yes, what happens when I take up my space, by writing on the table about the table, nestled in the corner of the room? What happens, when I write about writing, when I write about the tables that appear as objects within phenomenology? It is no accident that I am writing about how such objects matter. I turn back toward my table, and begin writing again.